of the 'noisy' Hanuman Jayanti procession should answer why stones were also hurled at the police party that went to arrest the vandals.

Looking at the communal riots through a narrow political prism would surely lead to flawed conclusions and, consequently, wrong solutions. There is a perceptible awareness among Hindus that is not the result of a particular party's ascendance. Rather, this rising awareness, assertiveness and at times aggressiveness has been successfully utilised by the BJP to catapult itself to power. This rising awareness among Hindus should be seen as a continuation of a larger renaissance movement that preceded the struggle for independence and continued through the turbulent times of the tragic Partition.

The highly truncated but otherwise noble idea of secularism turned out to be a tool in the hands of the new narrative-setters who inundated the corridors of power. Minority rights were considered more sacrosanct than the fundamental rights guaranteed by the Constitution. In fact, in 2006, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh said Muslims should have the first claim on resources. The priorities set by the political class of that time proved to be a red rag to distraught Hindu groups that were nurturing the wounds of Partition and felt terribly short-changed.

It is nobody's argument that "an eye for an eye" reaction should be condoned or left unpunished. Pelting stones on a Hindu religious procession is as contemptible as vandalising a mosque. Both are punishable offences and should be treated as such, nothing more, nothing less. We must stop analysing communal flare-ups with different yardsticks.

The larger issue, however, is the responsibility of the leaders of respective communities to rein in the fringe elements and prevail over the troublemakers, by force or through legal recourse if needed. The ban on triple talaq and the court orders on hijab should be seen as equivalent to the ban on sati and allowing Dalits to enter temples. There is little doubt that Islam is perceived as being at loggerheads with democracy, human rights and gender equality on the grounds that these are not compatible with the divinely ordained irrevocable laws that bound a small sect some 14 centuries ago.

The widespread riots in Spain and Sweden have dented the image of Muslims further. It is argued that these rioters have nothing in common with the poor Muslims in India. That may be true to a large extent, but the larger Muslim brotherhood's loyal adherence to the holy book and the commonality of the core principles of Islam cannot be overlooked. Many of the Muslims in Europe do not belong to the countries they live in. The local traditions, culture and languages are alien to them. Most of them have sought asylum in these countries. They came as refugees and immensely benefited from the social security systems there. Yet they refuse to integrate with the locals, and demand separate and special extra-constitutional rights that are part of their religious ordination. Again, images of large gatherings of Muslims offering namaz in Times Square and other public places point to the emergence of an "us versus them" narrative in these places. The general argument is that there are not enough places of worship to offer prayers and hence Muslims congregate in public places. This becomes the basis for demanding more space for Muslims, besides special rights and freedom to follow the laws prescribed by the religious book rather than the laws of the land.

**PELTING STONES ON A HINDU PROCESSION IS AS CONTEMPTIBLE AS VANDALISING A MOSQUE**

Those who argue that Islam as it is practised today is divinely ordained should ponder over the aberrations that have crept in due to human interpretations at various times in its historical evolution amid heterogeneous cultures and local traditions in different parts of the world. Christianity has come a long way from the harsh and intolerant Justinian laws of the sixth century and integrated itself with modern societies. Islam, too, needs to undergo drastic reforms and adjust itself to the changed social and political norms. Any stagnation and refusal to modernise will give the *mullah*s and *moulvi*s a greater hold over their followers, but in the process also increase alienation, the number of ghettos, and the false and often calamitous notions of victimhood.

A number of Islamic societies and groups in democracies, especially in Asia, have been deeply influenced by the Arab version of Islam. This has led to the de-culturalisation of the faithful, alienating them from their roots, cultural moorings and identity. Unfortunately, any suggestion to avoid the dictates of "Arabisation" is seen as an infringement of religious freedom. When a court of law functioning under the provisions of the Constitution of India says hijab is not part of the basic tenets of Islam or frowns upon compulsory halal certification, the *mullah*s and *moulvi*s raise the war cry of "*Islam khatrey mein hai* (Islam is in danger)". This has to change.

Reform in Islam is possible only if there is a free and frank public debate and a readiness to accept that religious practices are prone to get corrupted, especially if they are left to human interpretations. Reform among Hindus has a long history and it is an ongoing process. Any society that shuns reform and chooses to stay rooted in obscurantism is destined to decay and become irrelevant. ■